National States Geographic Information Council (NSGIC) 2026 Membership Survey Report

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Executive Summary

The 2026 NSGIC Membership Survey provides insights into member demographics, participation barriers, national advocacy priorities, organizational challenges, and perceptions of NSDI progress. Respondents represent state geospatial leaders, federal partners, academia, and business partners.

Key findings indicate strong national alignment on foundational geospatial datasets, persistent funding and staffing constraints, increasing interest in leadership roles despite workload limitations, and the need for improved communication around the NGC's role.

Key Survey Findings

1. High Priority for Foundational Datasets

Strong national alignment on NG911, imagery, 3D elevation, geodesy workforce, and FGDC collaboration.

2. Workforce and Funding Constraints

Many states lack dedicated GIS program staffing, sustainable funding, and formal governance authority.

3. Travel and Approval Barriers

Cost and administrative limitations reduce national participation.

4. Leadership Interest Increasing

Respondents show interest despite workload and organizational constraints.

5. Need for Improved NGC Visibility

Members desire simpler, direct messaging and regular communication.

Recommendations

1. Increase Virtual Engagement Options

More virtual caucuses and peer-state exchanges would reduce travel barriers.

2. Develop Advocacy Toolkits

Provide legislator briefings, ROI calculators, and messaging templates.

3. Strengthen NGC Communications

Quarterly updates, dedicated newsletters, and simplification of governance messaging.

4. Support Workforce & Governance Development

Offer mentorship, onboarding templates, governance playbooks, and skills pathways.

5. Improve GMA Efficiency

Shorten assessment timelines, stabilize rubrics, and provide clearer documentation.

Conclusion

The 2026 Membership Survey reveals a highly engaged geospatial community committed to improving foundational dataset coordination, strengthening national policy alignment, and advancing the NSDI. Despite barriers related to funding, staffing, and travel, respondents demonstrate strong interest in participating in national initiatives and contributing to collaborative geospatial governance.

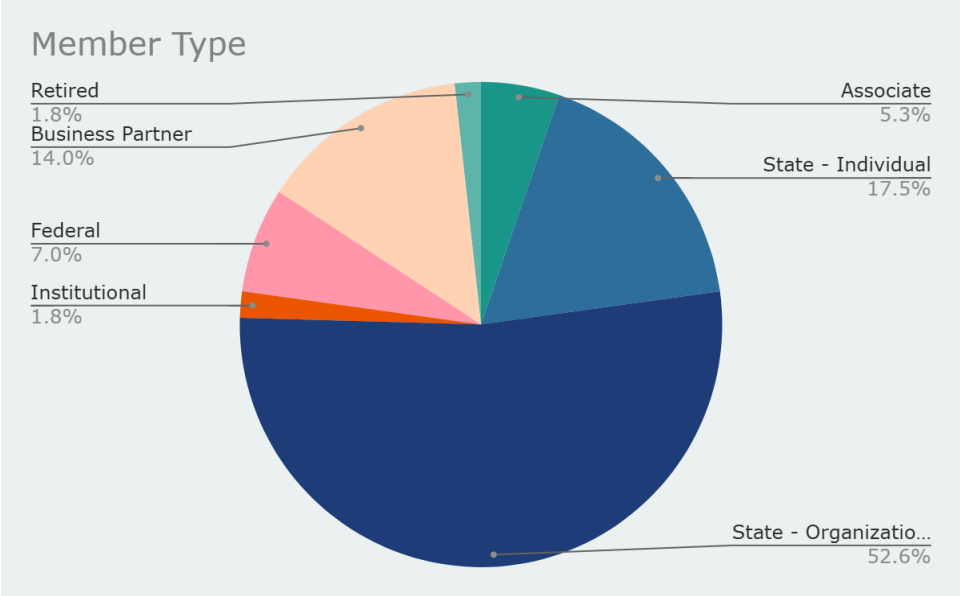
Membership Overview

Items assessed:

- Member Type
- Job Position/Title
- Length of Involvement
- GIO Status
- Interest in Leadership

Respondents span GIOs, deputy directors, coordinators, analysts, researchers, and business partners. Leadership interest varies, with many citing limited time or need for greater familiarity with NSGIC operations. GIO engagement remains strong, though some respondents report travel or legislative session constraints.

Member Type Distribution

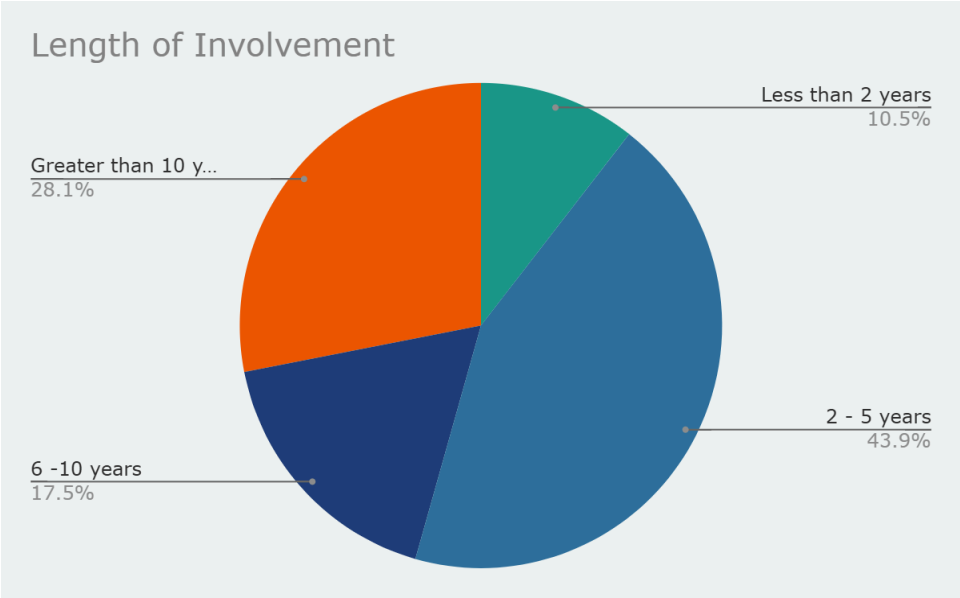


This chart illustrates the distribution of NSGIC membership types across the survey population. The largest share of respondents belong to State – Organizational categories, indicating high engagement from state agencies responsible for statewide GIS coordination. The distribution reinforces **NSGIC's broad national reach, with state-level participants forming the backbone of the organization's collaborative and governance activities.**

Job Position / Title Distribution

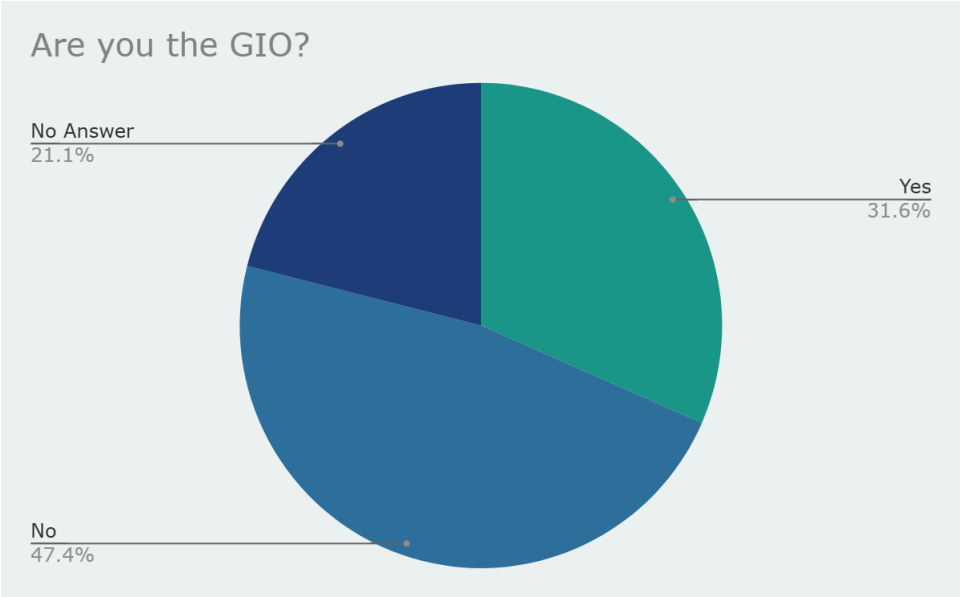
Responses to this question reflected a range of professional roles among survey participants. Common titles included GIO (3), GIS Manager (2), and Deputy Director (2). The variety of positions suggests that NSGIC membership encompasses technical leads, executive decision-makers, mid-level managers, subject-matter specialists, and private-sector representatives, reflecting the multidisciplinary nature of the geospatial community.

Length of Involvement in NSGIC



This figure summarizes how long respondents have been involved with NSGIC. The largest group reports greater than 10 years, demonstrating strong long-term membership retention. Mid-level experience ranges from 2–5 years to 6–10 years, with newer members (<2 years) also present, representing NSGIC's continual ability to attract new talent. Overall, the data underscores NSGIC's value as a long-standing professional community.

GIO Representation (Yes/No)



A substantial number of respondents do not hold GIO titles but work in state-level GIS programs, reflecting NSGIC's broader statewide engagement beyond official GIO positions. Those who do hold GIO roles represent a critical leadership segment guiding statewide policy, governance, and data initiatives.

Beyond networking and interstate collaboration, what specific benefits or values do you gain or hope to gain from your involvement with NSGIC?

Analyzing responses across state, federal, local, and private sector members reveals **six primary value themes**:

- **Applied State-to-State Learning & Operational Benchmarking:** Members rely on NSGIC to benchmark organizational charts, GIO staffing models, state council structures, and GIS governance. Respondents frequently cite learning from both successes and failures of other states on technical projects like AWS cloud migrations, parcel layers, NG9-1-1, and 3D Hydrography (3DHP).
- **Federal Policy Alignment & Early Initiative Awareness:** Members value early visibility into federal data programs, technical shifts, and national efforts—specifically referencing the Census Bureau, USGS (3DHP/LiDAR), and NOAA NGS (NSRS datum modernization)—allowing states to align programs early and prepare for federal grant opportunities.
- **Collective Advocacy & Industry Influence:** Members value having a unified voice to shape national spatial data infrastructure (NSDI), influence policy, and elevate the GIS profession. Members also highlight advocating for specific domains like emergency management.
- **Vendor Engagement & Private-Public Partnerships:** Private sector partners gain visibility into state program needs and business opportunities, while state members appreciate direct dialogue with industry partners to evaluate emerging technologies.

- **Subject Matter Expertise & Knowledge Base Access:** High utilization and appreciation of the My NSGIC discussion archives, working groups, and webinars for rapid, crowdsourced technical problem-solving.
- **Professional Development & Leadership Growth:** Programs such as the GIO Academy and committee leadership roles provide continuous professional growth and strategic inspiration.

How can NSGIC support your state better?

Analyzing member responses reveals **six primary opportunity areas** for NSGIC to expand and refine its support for member states:

- **Technical Training, Upskilling, & Onboarding Pipelines:** Members express a strong desire for NSGIC to help build internal capacity. Specific requests include:
    - **Curated Technical Briefings:** Short-turnaround research briefings on emerging technical topics (Cloud Native GIS, AI data automation, real-time sensor integration, NSRS modernization) to upskill technical staff without high costs.
    - **Onboarding & Professional Pathways:** Standardized onboarding templates and "think like a GIO" leadership resources to guide new state representatives, GIOs, and technical personnel.
    - **Credential Promotion:** Helping promote industry professional credentials like GISP and GISP-E (Emerging GIS Professional).
- **Resource Curation & Knowledge Architecture:** While members love the community feedback, they struggle with information retrieval across forums. They request:
    - A dedicated, organized library of useful documents, templates, and one-pagers outside the standard discussion boards.
    - Capturing and organizing answers from GIO-prompted questions in the State Caucus forum into a searchable knowledge base.
    - Creating a clearinghouse-focused working group (similar to MAGIC) for sharing data management, maintenance, and open data distribution best practices.
- **Federal Advocacy, Legislative Toolkits, & ROI:** Members look to NSGIC as a force multiplier for state advocacy. Priorities include:
    - **Plug-and-Play Templates:** Standardized one-page handouts and messaging toolkits explaining the ROI of state GIS programs, foundational data, open data, and NG9-1-1 to state legislators and executive leadership.
    - **Expanded Federal Partnerships:** Building on the success of 3DNTM/3DHP advocacy to drive national coordination and state-federal co-funding in imagery (NAIP and satellite data).
    - **Formal Commenting:** Continued NSGIC input and formal comments on proposed federal legislation affecting geospatial policy.
- **Internal Marketing & Outreach Assets:** New representatives and state leads find it hard to explain NSGIC's value to internal staff. Members requested short marketing

clips, flyers, and shareable content showcasing NSGIC benefits to distribute across state agencies (e.g., TDEC in Tennessee).

- **Committee Revitalization & Collaboration Spaces:** Suggestions to boost participation in lower-attended groups (Emergency Preparedness, Geospatial Programs) and create dedicated spaces for state technical staff, academic partners, and federal partners to collaborate directly.
- **Conference Logistics & State Approval Sensitivity:** Members raised logistical and administrative friction regarding events:
    - **Travel Approval Constraints:** Keeping agendas strictly focused on technical and policy value—minimizing social references like golf or riverboats on official agenda documents—to prevent travel rejection by high-level state audit authorities.
    - **Accessibility:** Distributing event locations across regions, lowering registration fees where possible, and offering more online training options.

What geospatial challenges does your state face that NSGIC could help you with?

Analyzing member responses reveals five major operational, technical, and political challenge areas where members seek NSGIC's guidance and resources:

- **Executive Advocacy, Funding, & ROI Justification:** Proving the economic value of GIS is the single most common challenge. Members face tight budgets, legislative skepticism, and the political erosion of public trust in data. Respondents specifically request:
    - **ROI Calculators & Case Studies:** Concrete tools demonstrating how geospatial infrastructure (e.g., imagery, parcels) saves money across non-GIS departments like tax assessment, emergency response, and agriculture.
    - **Third-Party Messaging Toolkits:** "Official" NSGIC-branded advocacy materials to present to state legislators, governors, and county supervisors to justify budget expansion and protect sustained appropriations.
- **Statewide Data Program Implementation:** Members struggle to establish and maintain recurring funding for critical statewide framework datasets. Key focus areas include:
    - High-resolution aerial imagery and 5-year LiDAR cycles.
    - Integrated statewide parcel layers and statewide open data initiatives.
    - Navigating Next Generation 9-1-1 (NG9-1-1) integration and federal reporting alignment (e.g., HPMS).
- **Governance, Leadership, & Relationship Sustainability:** Many states face structural hurdles, such as lacking a formal GIO, operating decentralized systems, or building statewide buy-in. Members seek guidance on:
    - **Governance Packages & Playbooks:** Proven blueprints for establishing state GIS governance, councils, and interim legislation.
    - **Institutionalizing Relationships:** Formalizing long-standing data-sharing relationships (via MOUs and NDAs) as veteran professionals retire and leadership shifts.

    - **Peer Mentorship:** Mentorship frameworks to help structure state offices or organize local GIS for smaller jurisdictions.
- **Technical Integration & Vendor-Neutral Training:** As GIS communities expand beyond traditional specialists, members cite a need for guidance on:
    - **Standardized Training Pathways:** Official NSGIC-recommended training curricula for various skill levels (Novice, AGOL, Spatial Analysis) that carry non-vendor authority.
    - **Emerging Technologies:** Best practices for integrating GeoAI solutions into state workflows and integrating GIS into major state IT modernization projects.
- **Federal Program Alignment & Technical Support:** Members cite friction in bridging state data to federal systems. A key pain point raised is the transition to USGS 3DHP, where members request practical outreach and technical training materials so state stewards can clearly understand, use, and communicate the data model to local stakeholders.

Please provide any additional topics/goals you feel should be a priority.

Note on Sample Size & Consensus: This question was optional. Out of 29 total survey participants, 17 members skipped the question, 2 replied "none", and 10 provided specific suggestions. These takeaways reflect individual member priorities or niche operational concerns rather than broad membership consensus.

Analyzing these 10 submissions reveals five distinct focus areas:

- **Federal-State Data Boundaries & Joint Funding (1 respondent):** A specific operational challenge was raised regarding federal programs acquiring remote sensing data along watershed boundaries, while states are legally restricted from spending state funds outside geographic lines. The respondent suggested NSGIC help facilitate tradeoff models between these boundaries.
- **National Governance, Strategic Alliances, & Policy (3 respondents):** Suggestions included strengthening NSDI/SSDI integration, expanding outreach to executive policy organizations (**NASCIO**, **NGA**, **NCSL**), advocating for NG9-1-1, and reviving national efforts toward a National Parcel Database.
- **Emerging Technology & AI (1 respondent):** Elevating Artificial Intelligence (AI) as a priority topic across NSGIC and the National Geospatial Collaborative (NGC).
- **NSGIC Staffing, Operations, & Website Maintenance (2 respondents):** Suggestions that NSGIC add staff capacity to keep website content and State Pages updated, revive "State Spotlights," and improve working group engagement.
- **Conference Optics & Travel Approval Friction (1 respondent):** A warning regarding public scrutiny on state travel, noting that scheduled leisure/social activities (golf outings, bus tours, "fun days") during conferences make it difficult or impossible for state employees to get travel approved by auditors.

Please use this space to share any additional feedback with NSGIC Leadership.

Note on Sample Size & Consensus: This open-ended feedback question was optional. Out of 29 total survey participants, 11 members skipped the question, 5 indicated no additional feedback ("none"/"n/a"), and 13 provided specific comments.

The overwhelming majority of comments expressed gratitude, with a few targeted operational suggestions.

Analyzing these submissions reveals four primary themes:

- **Widespread Gratitude & Leadership Recognition (9 respondents):** Members expressed deep gratitude for the time, energy, and dedication that NSGIC leadership invests in a volunteer capacity. Multiple state leads highlighted the positive ripple effects in their home states (e.g., North Carolina, Rhode Island), noting that NSGIC involvement directly helped them grow professionally, build confidence, and foster regional inter-state collaboration.
- **Autonomy from Vendor Marketing in Presentations (1 respondent):** A state GIO raised concern over webinars co-presented alongside private vendors. While recognizing vendor financial contributions to the organization, the respondent emphasized that state leaders want to hear directly from peer GIOs and state staff about work accomplished independently—specifically noting that teams who draft their own strategic plans demonstrate stronger internal commitment than those using third-party vendors.
- **Committee Operational & Communication Support (1 respondent):** A committee leader requested more dedicated NSGIC staff support to assist with administrative duties, messaging consistency, and audience engagement, noting that relying on personal social media accounts (e.g., LinkedIn) yields mixed results for driving meeting attendance.
- **Broader Representation & Local Government Outreach (1 respondent):** A suggestion to actively recruit and support more local government participation at annual conferences, as bridging state and local knowledge sharing benefits the entire geospatial ecosystem.

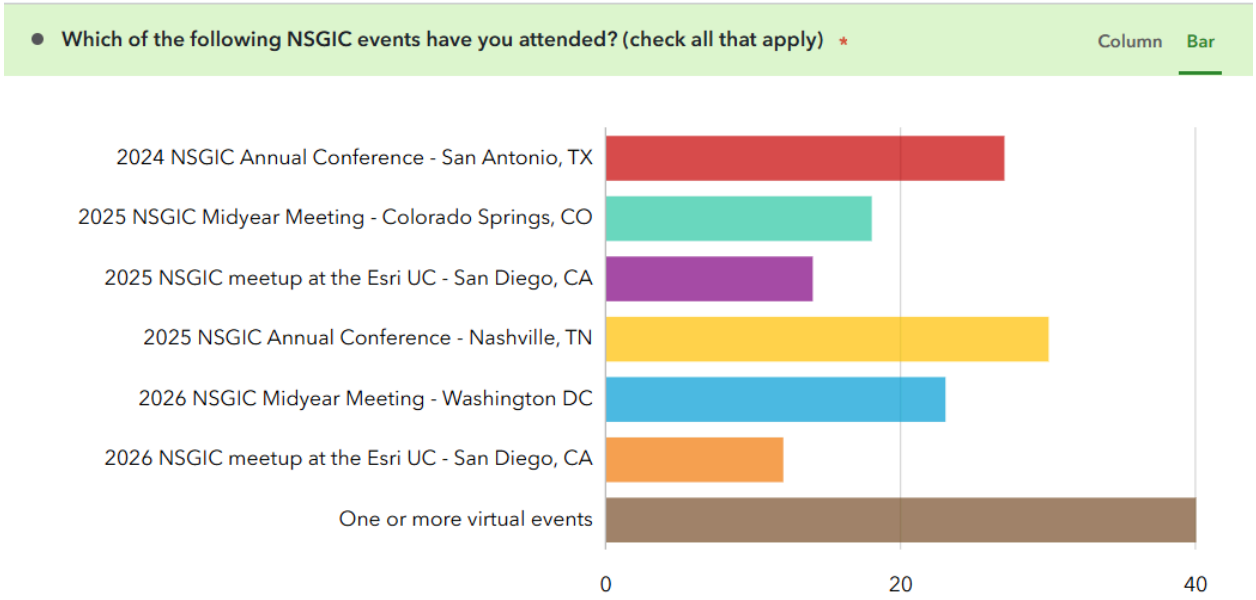
Event Attendance & Participation Barriers

Key fields:

- Event Attendance
- Barriers to Attending Meetings
- Barriers to Serving in Leadership
- Legislative Access
- Interest in Capitol Hill Visits

Barriers most frequently identified:

- Cost of travel
- Limited or denied travel approval
- Legislative-session conflicts
- High workloads and insufficient staffing
- Organizational reluctance to authorize national participation



Despite barriers, respondents consistently express interest in federal advocacy and peer-state collaboration. While there is strong interest in national-level engagement, virtual options significantly expand participation opportunities.

What are the barriers to attending the annual or midyear meeting?

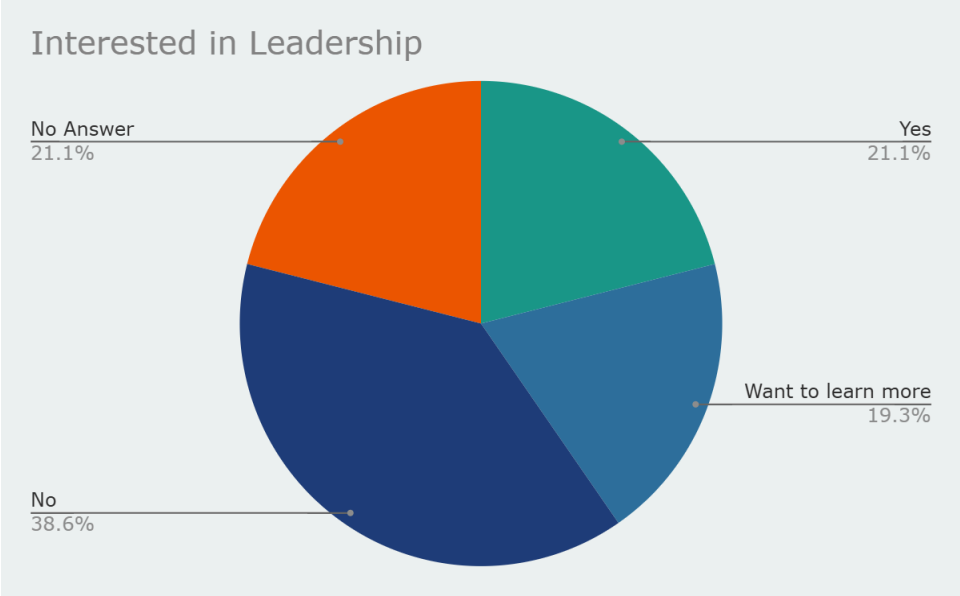
Analyzing the responses highlights five main operational, financial, and policy barriers preventing or limiting conference attendance:

- **Budgetary Constraints & Direct Costs:** Cost remains the single most dominant barrier. Members cite rising travel costs, expensive registration fees, and shrinking state and corporate travel budgets. Budget impasses, spending freezes, and cases where state policies explicitly prohibit reimbursing registration fees directly stop members from attending.
- **Strict Travel Policies & Approval Processes:** Severe administrative rules limit participation across many states. Restrictions include total bans on out-of-state travel, blanket travel freezes, caps on the number of staff allowed to attend (often limited to 1–3 leadership positions, such as the GIO and deputies), and complex justification requirements to prove the business "purpose" of the trip.
- **Scheduling Conflicts & Legislative Timelines:** Timing creates major conflicts for state leadership:
    - **Midyear Meeting:** Frequently overlaps with state legislative sessions (typically held in early spring), making it difficult for State GIOs to leave their capital.
    - **Annual Meeting & Fiscal Years:** Clashes with state fiscal year-end transitions (which shut down financial processing for up to 2.5 months), family commitments (like college drop-offs), or competing fall industry events.
- **Location & Geography:** Travel distance heavily impacts participation. Travel from distant states (such as Hawai‘i) is cost-prohibitive. Furthermore, members noted that

holding the Midyear Meeting away from Washington, DC reduces the primary value of attending—direct access to federal decision-makers.

- **Workplace Capacity & Role Changes:** Small team sizes make it challenging to cover workload for 4 or 5 days of travel. Additionally, changing job roles (e.g., transitioning off state councils to single-agency roles or retiring) makes justifying attendance or obtaining employer funding significantly harder.

Interest in Leadership Roles



A sizeable group expresses interest, often conditional on time availability or approval, while others note constraints such as workload, unfamiliarity with expectations, or agency limitations. The trend indicates an ongoing pipeline of potential leaders who may step into future governance positions as capacity allows.

What are the barriers to serving in a NSGIC leadership role (i.e., Board of Directors, Secretary, Treasurer, Working Group or Committee Chair)?

Analyzing member responses reveals five core themes explaining why members hesitate or decline to take on leadership roles within NSGIC:

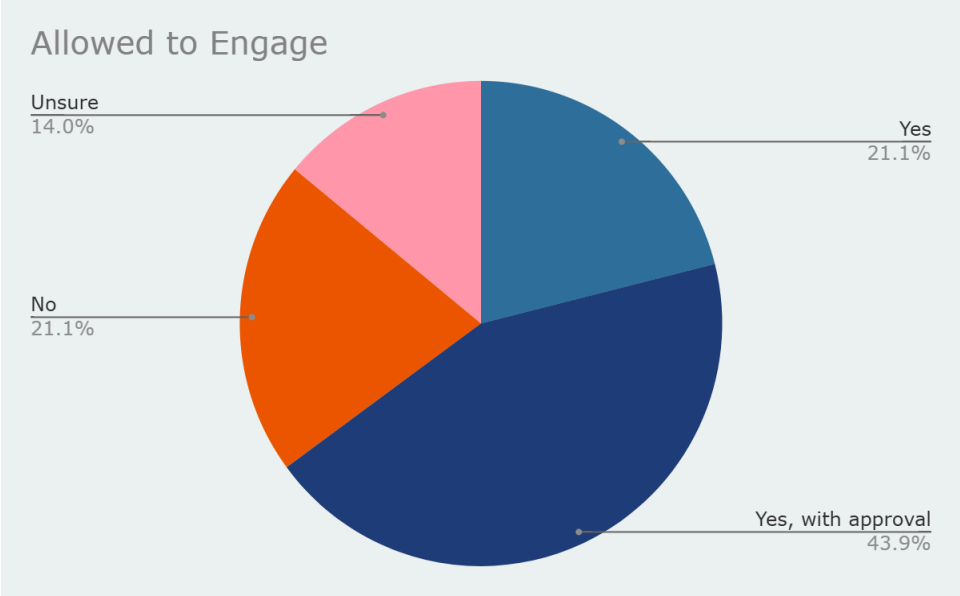
- **Capacity Constraints & Time Demands:** Time availability is overwhelmingly the primary barrier cited across respondents. Specific drivers include:
    - Running single-person or understaffed state/local GIS offices.
    - Balancing existing commitments with State GIS Councils or regional initiatives.
    - Juggling full-time job expectations, academic degrees, and family life alongside volunteer duties.
- **New Member Onboarding & Knowledge Gaps:** Newer representatives feel unprepared for governance roles. They express a need to attend conferences reliably, build network relationships, and gain a foundational understanding of NSGIC's operations before taking on board or committee chair responsibilities.

- **Role Alignment & Hierarchical Perception:** Several respondents feel their specific career level or organization limits their eligibility:
    - Non-GIO or "rank-and-file" staff feel they are too low in their agency's chain of command to represent leadership.
    - University, academic, and local government members view NSGIC leadership as predominantly tailored toward State GIOs.
    - Roles fall outside official job descriptions, making it hard to secure management permission to allocate work hours to NSGIC governance.
- **State Leadership Cycling & Burnout:** Multiple respondents noted that their states have historically contributed heavily to NSGIC leadership (furnishing past Presidents, Secretaries, and Board members). These veteran members are deliberately stepping back to prevent burnout, allow other states to contribute, and let their agency focus on internal program resets.
- **Meeting Load & Operational Logistics:** The sheer volume of recurring meetings required for executive roles (Board, Officer, or Committee leadership) creates friction with day-to-day work schedules, especially when remote meeting loads compete with primary state deliverables.

Advocacy Overview

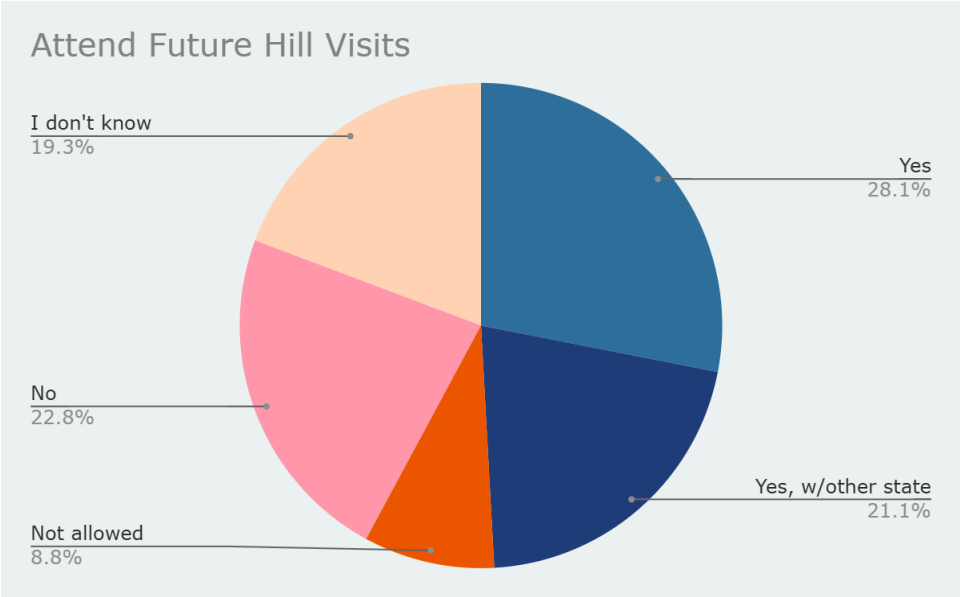
The Advocacy Priorities field contains multi-select national priorities (e.g., NG_911, 3DEP, Digital Coast Act, Address Efficiency Act). These were manually categorized into seven national priority areas based on standardized themes. The priorities demonstrate strong national focus on NG911, 3D elevation, imagery programs, and FGDC/NSDI coordination.

Legislative Engagement Permissions



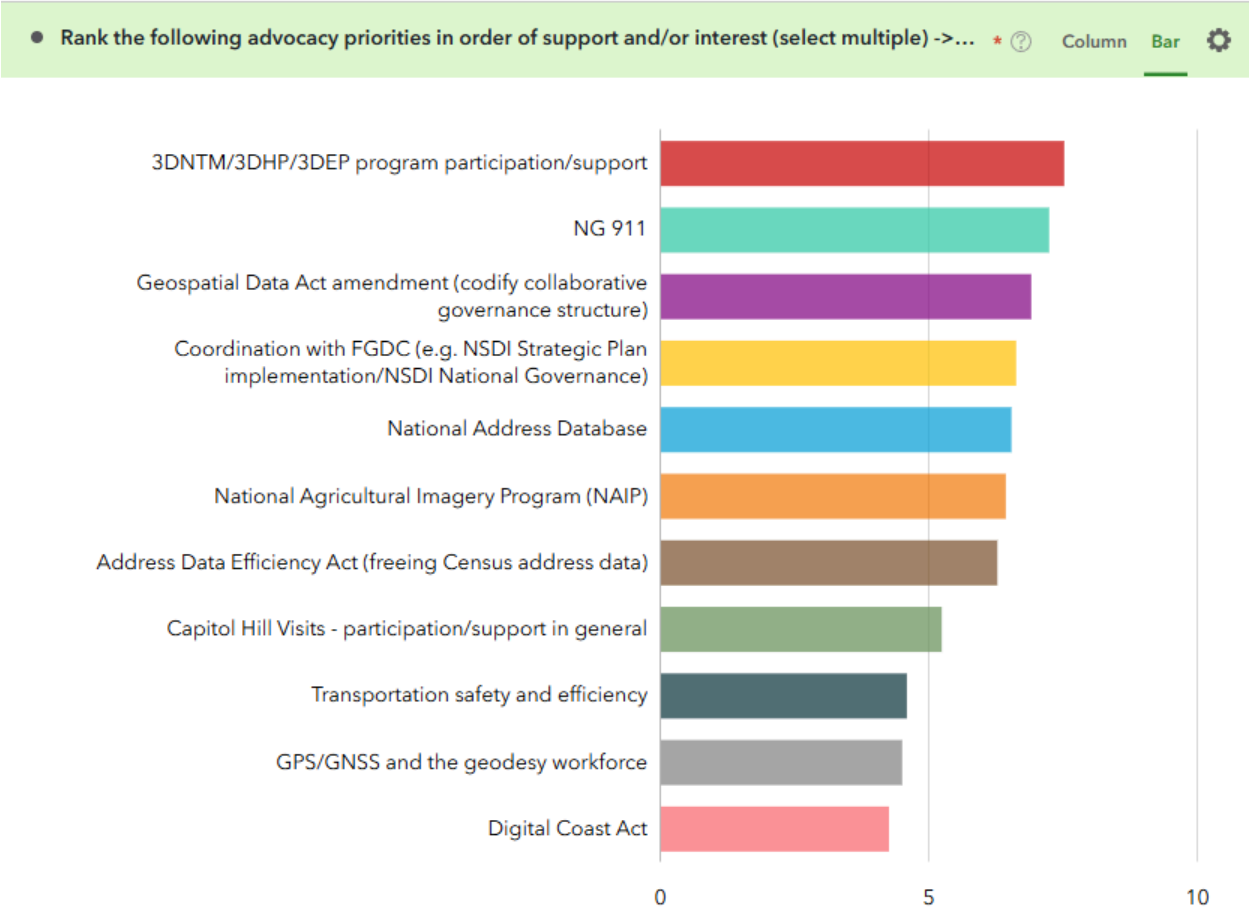
The figure shows which respondents are allowed to engage their legislature. Many respondents report they **are not** permitted to do so by agency policy, while others require explicit approval. A smaller group is fully allowed. **This suggests NSGIC should continue developing advocacy materials that help members work within varying administrative constraints.**

Interest in Attending Capitol Hill Visits



The chart reveals considerable interest in participating in Capitol Hill advocacy — even among respondents who are not currently allowed to engage. The chart demonstrates support for NSGIC's national advocacy program and willingness to contribute when permitted.

National Advocacy Priorities by Category



This data shows counts for **seven advocacy priority groups** derived from the Advocacy Priorities field:

- Addressing/NG911 (68)
- 3D Programs (61)
- Imagery (57)
- Geodesy (54)
- Legislative Advocacy (49)
- Transportation (46)
- FGDC/NSDI (43)

This chart reflects consistent, multi-state alignment with NSDI-related initiatives.

Do you have any additional feedback for the Advocacy Committee?

Note on Sample Size & Member Consensus: Out of 29 total survey participants, 1 member skipped, 9 explicitly declined follow-up ("no"/"not at this time"), and 19 provided qualitative feedback, praise, or policy suggestions. While direct follow-up

requests were modest, members used this prompt to offer high praise for NSGIC's current advocacy momentum.

Analyzing member responses reveals five main themes regarding NSGIC's advocacy strategy and organizational logistics:

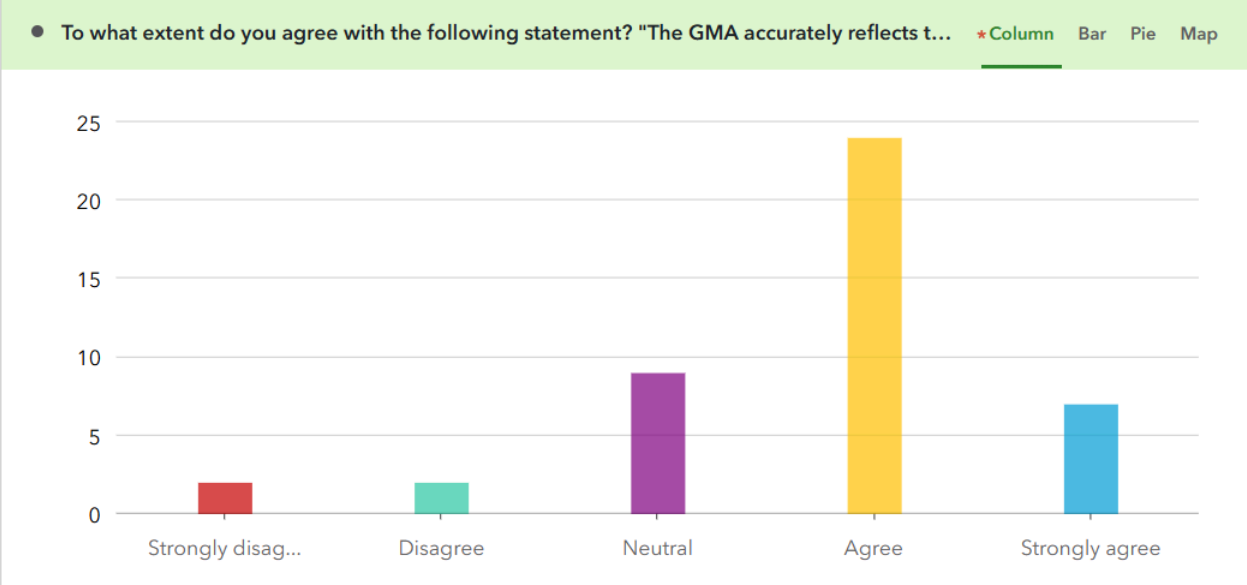
- **Widespread Praise for Advocacy Momentum & Staff:** Members expressed gratitude for NSGIC's advocacy direction, noting that the Advocacy Committee has become noticeably more effective. Staff members were praised for their high responsiveness, professionalism, and support for state priorities.
- **Addressing Policy Gaps (National Parcels & Critical Infrastructure):**
    - **National Parcel Database:** Multiple respondents emphasized that a National Parcel Database was absent as a selectable priority option in the survey prompt and strongly urged leadership to position it as a core national advocacy issue.
    - **Critical Infrastructure:** Members requested that national advocacy messaging explicitly incorporate critical infrastructure data needs, which remain underrepresented in current national datasets.
- **Active Peer Support & Committee Volunteers:** Members expressed interest in stepping up, with respondents volunteering to serve on the Advocacy Committee. Additionally, states that have fully achieved major implementation milestones (such as North Carolina with Next Generation 9-1-1) voiced a desire to stay actively involved in national advocacy to support other states still navigating the transition.
- **Conference Logistics & Time Commitments:** A respondent noted that attending 5-day annual meetings creates operational strain back at the office, suggesting that shaving 1–2 days off the event duration would make attendance far more manageable for state staff.
- **Role Alignment & Decision-Making Capacity:** Several non-GIO or technical support respondents noted that while they value the advocacy efforts, they do not hold decision-making authority at the state level to lead formal state-level advocacy interactions.

GMA Overview

GMA Agreement Statements

Respondents generally agree the GMA reflects state maturity, but note concerns about:

- Expanded question difficulty
- Grading inconsistencies (e.g., addressing vs NG911 overlap)
- Leaf-on imagery grading misalignment
- Desire for more stable scoring criteria
- Need for external validation or auditing



If the GMA does not accurately reflect your program's maturity, what is missing or overstated?

Note on Sample Size & Member Consensus: This question generated significant detailed feedback from state GIOs and state representatives. Out of 29 total survey participants, 6 skipped the question, 8 noted that the GMA was accurate or worked well, and 21 provided specific criticisms regarding methodology changes, rubric weighting, and category definitions.

Analyzing the submissions reveals six primary critique areas regarding the 2025 Geospatial Maturity Assessment (GMA):

- **The "Leaf-On" Orthoimagery Penalty:** The single most cited technical grievance involves the 2025 Orthoimagery grading criteria. Multiple states (including North Carolina and Missouri) noted receiving default "C+" or failing grades on leaf-on imagery simply

because they do not spend state funds to enhance the federal NAIP program. Members emphasized that penalizing a state for not enhancing a dataset it doesn't need—when it already maintains an advanced, state-funded leaf-off program—misrepresents maturity.

- **Rubric Instability & Longitudinal Comparison Issues:** State leads expressed frustration with major rubric changes introduced in the 2025 cycle. Dramatic score drops (e.g., dropping from an 'A' to a 'D+' in Coordination or 'B-' in Transportation) force GIOs to explain "slipping grades" to state legislators and executive leadership, even when underlying state programs actually improved. Members strongly requested rubric stability across multiple cycles.
- **Misleading "Coordination" Title:** A state lead strongly urged NSGIC to retitle the "Coordination" theme to "State Support" or "Governance Infrastructure". Executive leaders interpret a low "Coordination" grade as a poor performance evaluation of the GIO personally, when the grade actually reflects a lack of statutory authority, missing council mandates, or zero dedicated state funding.
- **Disadvantage for Rural, Western, & Federal-Land States:** Western and highly rural states (e.g., Utah) noted that the GMA's heavy weighting on high-frequency, statewide leaf-off imagery updates is financially impossible due to massive geographic footprints and large percentages of non-taxable federal land. The assessment fails to balance update frequency against spatial resolution (e.g., 3-inch urban captures).
- **Missing Programmatic & Governance Context:**
    - **Emergency Management:** Complete lack of metrics evaluating how GIS is integrated into state emergency management and public safety operations.
    - **Structural Complexity:** Failure to account for state administrative factors such as "home rule" status, total county count, or state population.
    - **Hydrography Omission:** The removal of hydrography as a graded theme left non-technical stakeholders without a relatable benchmark dataset.
- **Survey Length & Completion Burden:** Multiple respondents highlighted that the 2025 survey was excessively long, difficult to collaborate on internally (single-user Survey123 format), and required documenting projects completed a decade ago.

If NSGIC could change one thing about the GMA to make it more valuable to your state, what would it be?

Note on Sample Size & Member Alignment: This question prompted actionable feedback from 20 state leads, with 9 stating they were too new or lacked suggestions. The primary focus centered on making the GMA more useful as a legislative funding tool while reducing the administrative burden on state volunteers.

Analyzing member submissions reveals six core operational changes to increase the value of the Geospatial Maturity Assessment (GMA):

- **Scoring Stability & Consistency Across Cycles:** The most frequent request was to stop changing grading criteria between assessments. Moving goalposts force GIOs to spend valuable time explaining artificial grade changes to legislative committees rather than advancing strategic priorities.
- **Measuring Program Sustainability, Funding, & FTEs:** Members want the GMA to look beyond whether data merely *exists*. They recommend adding indicators for:

    - **Funding Permanence & Risk:** Highlighting when an 'A' grade dataset relies on fragile, one-time grants or expiring federal cycles vs. recurring state appropriations.
    - **Workforce & Statutory Context:** Tracking FTE staffing levels, statutory authority, and workforce training programs to justify resource expansion requests to state executives.
- **Legislative Release Timing & External Audit Support:**
    - **Timeline Alignment:** Deliver GMA results in late summer when state finance committees assemble budget requests, rather than late in the legislative cycle.
    - **Professional Administration & Peer Review:** Secure external funding to hire administrative staff—reducing reliance on volunteer labor to speed up delivery—and explore independent verification to strengthen the GMA's standing as an authoritative standard.
- **Streamlining & Question Reduction:** Members urged NSGIC to streamline the assessment itself by resolving category overlap between Addressing, NG9-1-1, and Transportation, dropping irrelevant requirements (like leaf-on NAIP enhancements), and reducing survey length.
- **Executive Summaries & Peer Mentorship:** State leads requested decision-maker-friendly executive summaries, comparative benchmarks against neighboring states, and structured peer-mentorship programs connecting lower-scoring states with high-maturity states for guidance.
- **Retitling the "Coordination" Theme:** Reiterated calls to rename the "Coordination" category so executive leaders do not interpret low governance or funding grades as a reflection of GIO job performance.

What decisions are you trying to influence in your state that the current GMA does not adequately help you support?

Note on Sample Size & Member Alignment: Out of 29 total survey participants, 2 skipped, 10 indicated no specific gap or were too new to evaluate, and 17 provided concrete examples of state decision-making hurdles where the current GMA framework falls short.

Analyzing member responses highlights six key decision-making areas where state GIS leaders need stronger analytical support than the current report cards provide:

- **Securing Multi-Year Recurring Funding & Federal Matching Grants:** A primary friction point is establishing predictable, multi-year funding cycles. GIOs need data to persuade state budget directors to support recurring 5-year imagery/LiDAR refresh cycles (acquiring 1/5th of the state annually) and allocate state matching dollars required to unlock federal partnership grants (e.g., USGS 3DEP and 3DHP).
- **The "False Maturity" Paradox (Risks Behind High Grades):** Several states (notably Missouri) pointed out a critical strategic flaw: high GMA grades in themes like Elevation or Leaf-Off Imagery create a false impression among legislative stakeholders that these programs are "fully funded and complete." The GMA does not help GIOs communicate the underlying risks—such as stale data currency, fragmented non-standard collections across agencies, or reliance on expiring one-time grants.

- **Governance Mandates, Central Office Authority, & Solvency:** States struggling to formalize governance find that the GMA does not sufficiently aid in:
    - Codifying central State GIS Offices with statutory authority to mandate authoritative datasets.
    - Navigating forced cost-recovery or project-based fee models where GIOs must constantly scramble to remain solvent.
- **Emerging Technology, GeoAI, & Open Data Governance:** Members noted that state CIOs and CDOs are urgently asking for policy guidance on **GeoAI readiness**, ethical AI data usage, and open data governance. The current GMA offers no metrics or benchmarks on how states are approaching AI integration.
- **Quantifiable Return on Investment (ROI):** State leaders frequently noted that executive decision-makers care most about economic impact. The GMA evaluates data existence and governance metrics, but lacks built-in ROI frameworks to prove how geospatial investments save state taxpayer dollars.
- **Specialized Program Datasets (Hydrography & Historical Imagery):**
    - **Hydrography:** States making major 2026 strides in state-level hydrography lack a dedicated assessment theme to benchmark progress against national peers.
    - **Historical Imagery Catalogs:** The GMA does not account for the temporal depth of imagery collections, offering no leverage to justify funding the digitization and archiving of valuable historical aerial film/prints.

NGC Overview

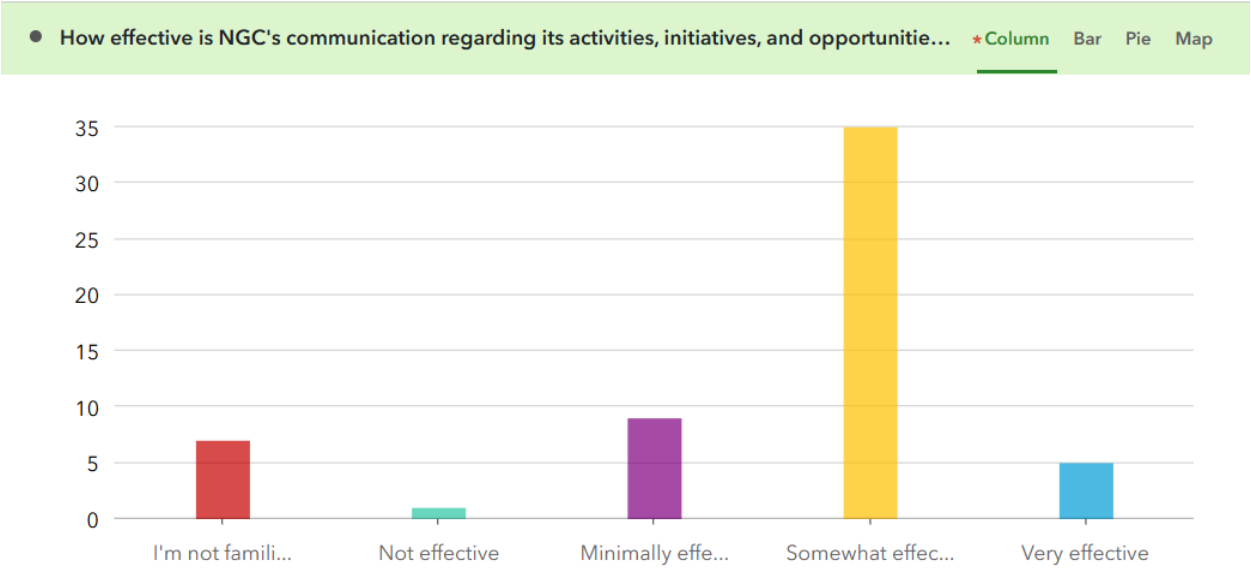
NGC Communication Effectiveness

Several respondents expressed:

- Limited understanding of NGC vs NSGIC
- Desire for clearer role descriptions
- Requests for more frequent updates
- Interest in NGC involvement but uncertainty about activities

Overall, members value the NGC and believe it plays a crucial role in advancing NSDI coordination, but needs more frequent updates, simpler messaging about NGC's role, and improved dissemination channels outside NSGIC conferences.

NGC Question Review



What could NGC do to improve awareness, communication, or engagement with NSGIC members?

> *Note on Sample Size & Member Alignment*: This question generated high engagement, with 29 total respondents contributing 62 total line items. While many members praised recent presentation efforts, a significant portion of the membership reported being "fuzzy" on NGC's role or unaware of its specific activities outside of the major NSGIC conferences.

Analyzing member responses reveals five major action areas for the National Geospatial Collaborative (NGC) to build stronger awareness and engagement across NSGIC membership:

- **Role Delineation & Basic "NGC 101" Education:** A primary friction point is organizational clarity. Members frequently noted that leadership crossover between

NSGIC and NGC makes it hard to distinguish between the two entities. Members request:
    - Clear, direct messaging on the exact roles, mission distinctions, and synergy between NSGIC and NGC.
    - Concise "one-pager" summaries designed for newer or less experienced members who feel overwhelmed by complex national policy jargon.
- **Tangible Use Cases & State/Local ROI:** Members urge NGC to ground massive national initiatives (such as NSDI governance pilots or NAD 2.0) into local, practical realities. Communication should explicitly articulate *how* an NGC initiative benefits a specific state agency, local 911 district, or county office—tailoring the message for both advanced state programs and single-person GIS shops.
- **Predictable, Multi-Channel Communication:** Relying solely on conference updates or social media leaves many members out of the loop. Suggested communication updates include:
    - **Quarterly Email Digests:** Short, dedicated email newsletters summarizing recent progress, upcoming events, and opportunities to contribute.
    - **Digital Maintenance:** Keeping the NGC website fully updated and resolving broken links (members noted 404 errors on key project pages like the NSDI Governance Pilots page).
    - **Targeted Webinar Briefings:** Running short, standalone project-status webinars outside of multi-day conferences.
- **Direct Outreach & State Conference Presence:** To expand reach beyond national conference attendees, members encourage NGC leadership to:
    - Attend and present at state-level flagship GIS conferences.
    - Engage in 1-on-1 briefings with state GIOs, state council leads, and NSGIC committee chairs.
    - Advocate and build connections with national partner organizations like NASCIO and state legislatures.
- **Strengthening Academic, Student, & Private Sector Alignment:** Members see strong potential in leveraging new NSGIC student/academic memberships to partner on NGC research initiatives. Additionally, private-sector respondents noted that vendors/business partners are eager to contribute directly to NGC project goals if given clear mechanisms to participate.

Are there any additional specific initiatives, partnerships, funding opportunities, or emerging issues you believe NGC should explore?

Note on Sample Size & Member Consensus: Out of 29 total survey participants, 7 skipped this question and 13 indicated no additional topics ("none"/"no"/"na"). The remaining 9 respondents provided specific strategic suggestions or advised focusing on existing initiatives rather than launching new ones.

Analyzing the submissions reveals six key strategic focus areas for the National Geospatial Collaborative (NGC):

- **Advocacy for Foundational Federal Data Programs (NAIP):** A key concern raised was the financial instability of the USDA National Agriculture Imagery Program (NAIP). Respondents noted that budget pressures are pushing NAIP toward longer collection cycles, directly impacting states that rely on NAIP as their primary orthophoto source. Members urge NGC to prioritize advocacy for NAIP across federal, state, tribal, and local stakeholders.
- **National Parcel Database & NSDI Advancement:** Respondents expressed strong satisfaction that a National Parcel Database is becoming an initiative, encouraging NGC to maintain momentum alongside broader NSDI integration and data collaboration efforts.
- **AI & Data Integrity Dynamics:** Expanding on general AI discussions, a respondent highlighted a unique angle: examining the potential risks of AI altering, synthesizing, or corrupting foundational geospatial datasets, and establishing safeguards to preserve authoritative data provenance.
- **Software Licensing & Alternative Tech Stacks:** Members urged NGC to address the growing financial burden of enterprise GIS software licensing (specifically Esri) on state and local budgets, suggesting NGC explore alternative software options, open-source frameworks, and modern technical stacks.
- **Local Government Funding Structures:** Suggesting that NGC help identify or create funding pathways and sub-grant programs tailored to small, under-resourced local jurisdictions that are traditionally priced out of national initiatives.
- **Execution & Focus over Expansion:** One respondent cautioned against overextending NGC's scope, advising leadership to focus on creating and executing strong action plans for existing initiatives (e.g., NAD 2.0, NSDI Governance Pilots) before taking on new projects.

What nationally significant geospatial challenge or opportunity do you believe would most benefit from NGC leadership, coordination, or partnership development?

Note on Sample Size & Member Alignment: This question drew significant focus from 25 active respondents out of the 29 survey takers (4 skipped). The breadth of answers demonstrates that members see the National Geospatial Collaborative (NGC) as a key convener for national-scale policy, technical standards, and inter-agency coordination that individual state offices cannot solve alone.

Analyzing member responses reveals six primary strategic opportunities for NGC leadership:

- **Standards Formalization & Standards Committee Membership (INCITS):** A concrete operational proposal was submitted for NGC/NSGIC to join the **INCITS Geographic Information Systems Technical Committee**. Membership would allow NGC to appoint voting representatives, contribute expertise directly to official U.S. and ISO geospatial standards, and ensure state/local priorities shape national data specifications.

- **National Framework Datasets & Data Governance:** Members want NGC to scale successful collaborative frameworks (such as NAD 2.0) to other national multi-use datasets. Key priorities include:
    - Accelerating momentum toward a **National Parcel Database** and open national address data from the Census Bureau.
    - Bridging state spatial data infrastructures (SSDI) with the FGDC National Spatial Data Infrastructure (NSDI).
    - Safeguarding federal geospatial datasets against degradation, removal, or archival loss resulting from federal budget reallocations or DOGE efficiency cuts.
- **Emerging Technologies & Technical Transitions:** Members identified two major technological shifts requiring immediate NGC coordination:
    - **GeoAI Governance:** Providing unified state guidance on GeoAI, automated data processing, and ethical/technical AI standards (beyond single-vendor ecosystems).
    - **NSRS Datum Modernization:** Delivering education, technical toolkits, and transition support to states as NOAA's National Geodetic Survey rolls out the modernized datum framework.
- **National Joint Funding Models & Recurring Acquisitions:** Members recommend NGC coordinate multi-jurisdictional funding mechanisms to establish predictable, recurring re-acquisition cycles for foundational statewide LiDAR, elevation, and high-resolution imagery.
- **Niche National Use Cases & Life-Safety Operations:**
    - **Navigation Platform Integration:** Partnering with federal agencies and commercial mapping services (Google Maps, Apple Maps, Waze) to ingest authoritative state/local emergency evacuation routes.
    - **Elections:** Establishing dedicated focus areas and technical standards for election district/precinct mapping.
    - **Coastal & Digital Coast Alliances:** Strengthening multi-sector alignment across coastal management and tribal digital initiatives.
- **Equity, Outreach, & Workforce Development:**
    - **Local & Tribal Funding Pathways:** Leveraging philanthropic grants and flexible funding streams so small local governments and tribal nations can participate in national initiatives.
    - **GeoLiteracy for Decision-Makers:** Educating politicians, state legislators, and agency heads on the strategic value of geospatial infrastructure to build long-term policy support.

CLC Overview

As a Business Partner, what do you believe your role is with NSGIC? What do you believe it should be?

Note on Sample Size & Member Alignment: This question was specifically targeted at private sector members. Out of 29 total survey participants, 22 skipped the question, and 7 provided detailed perspective.

Analyzing these responses reveals three core themes regarding how private sector partners view their current and ideal role within NSGIC:

- **Strategic Advisors & State Program Supporters:** Business partners primarily view their mandate as helping states achieve their program goals, grow sustainably, and solve operational challenges. They emphasize providing private-sector perspectives on emerging technology, data management, and statewide project coordination rather than pushing hard-sell tactics.
- **Evolving Beyond Passive Sponsorship:** A key point of feedback is the desire for more meaningful, higher-impact interaction formats. Partners noted that brief formats (e.g., 5-minute "speed networking" sessions) are insufficient to showcase complex aerial mapping technology, big data initiatives, or in-depth state case studies. They advocate for collaborative conference environments where public and private leaders can develop genuine, long-term partnerships.
- **Bi-Directional Knowledge Transfer:** Respondents highlight that their role operates in two directions:
    1. *Outward:* Educating state, federal, and local leaders on modern geospatial solutions and industry best practices.
    2. *Inward:* Taking knowledge gathered at NSGIC—such as legislative trends, federal standards, and state program struggles—back to their own corporate leadership to better align future products and services with government needs.

Question: How can NSGIC support you better as a Business Partner?

Note on Sample Size & Member Alignment: This question was specifically targeted at private sector members. Out of 29 total survey participants, 22 skipped the question, 1 had no comment, and 6 provided direct suggestions.

Analyzing these responses reveals four primary ways NSGIC can enhance value for its private-sector sponsors:

- **Active Involvement in State Problem-Solving:** Business partners feel underutilized during national discussions. Rather than having states debate operational or funding challenges in isolation, partners urge NSGIC leadership to create collaborative sessions where state leads actively solicit private-sector technical input, commercial perspectives, and solution frameworks.
- **Driving Federal & State Meeting Attendance:** Private-sector investment in NSGIC relies on access to state and federal decision-makers. Partners urge NSGIC leadership to actively advocate for lifting state travel bans and petition key federal agencies (**USGS,**

USDA, NOAA, Census) to ensure consistent executive attendance at Annual and Midyear meetings.

- **Joint Public-Private Task Forces & Best Practices:** Respondents recommend building formal mechanism—such as collaborative working groups—where business partners and state representatives can pool industry knowledge, establish shared standards, and address common state GIS bottlenecks together.
- **Recognizing Commercial Value & Equal Membership Status:** Business partners appreciate being treated as true 'members' rather than mere vendors. They encourage NSGIC to maintain this inclusive culture while continuing to support avenues that help drive state-level business and contract opportunities for corporate sponsors.

What value do you get out of your partnership with NSGIC?

Note on Sample Size & Member Alignment: This question was specifically targeted at private sector corporate sponsors. Out of 29 total survey participants, 21 skipped the question and 7 provided detailed responses.

Analyzing these submissions reveals three primary value drivers that justify private-sector sponsorship in NSGIC:

- **Unrivaled Relationship Building & Access:** Corporate sponsors unanimously cite peer-to-peer networking as the single most important ROI factor. NSGIC provides a unique, collegial forum for vendors to connect directly with state GIOs, state council members, federal agency representatives, and fellow business partners outside of high-pressure sales environments.
- **Strategic Market Intelligence & State Insights:** Partners place high value on the "direct intelligence" gained through NSGIC sessions and caucus discussions. Access to real-time information regarding state priorities, upcoming procurement needs, budget shifts, and federal agency mandates allows vendors to tailor their technical solutions and business strategies directly to state realities.
- **Business Development & Revenue Sustainability:** Corporate members—including long-standing founding partners like Dewberry—highlight that NSGIC membership yields tangible business growth. The open dialogue fosters trust that leads directly to new client acquisition, stronger client retention, and sustainable government contract opportunities.

What are a few key projects you are working on with state partners?

Note on Sample Size & Member Alignment: This question was targeted specifically at private-sector corporate partners to capture active public-private technical collaborations. Out of 29 total survey participants, 24 skipped the question, and 5 corporate partners provided specific project details.

Analyzing these submissions reveals four core areas of active public-private project work across member states:

- **NextGen 9-1-1, Parcel, & Transportation Data Governance:** Corporate partners are actively collaborating with state GIO offices on core framework datasets. Key project scopes include implementing automated validation, aggregation, and provisioning pipelines for NG9-1-1 spatial data, establishing statewide parcel data governance frameworks, and performing linear referencing and transportation conflation.

- **Statewide High-Efficiency Dual-Collect Imagery & LiDAR:** Partners highlighted flagship statewide remote sensing programs. A notable highlight includes a major program in California that features a concurrent, high-efficiency dual-collect pilot pairing high-resolution aerial imagery with LiDAR sensors in a single flight acquisition.
- **USGS 3D Hydrography Program (3DHP) Implementation:** Business partners are actively assisting states in transitioning to the USGS 3D Hydrography Program framework. Specific 3DHP partnership projects were highlighted in Ohio and Tennessee.
- **Statewide Elevation & Sensor Mapping Programs:** Private mapping firms continue to partner with state agencies and local consortia to acquire and process wide-area high-density LiDAR and orthoimagery. Active multi-year statewide mapping programs were explicitly noted in Florida, Indiana, Wyoming, California, Ohio, and Tennessee.

Do you have new ideas for value propositions not listed above you would like to see NSGIC offer?

Note on Sample Size & Member Alignment: This question targeted new commercial ideas from private-sector corporate sponsors. Out of 29 total survey participants, 28 skipped the question, and 1 corporate partner provided a specific event proposal.

Analyzing this submission reveals a key insight into sponsor networking preferences:

- **Rethinking Event Formats for Sponsor ROI:** The respondent highlighted the success of non-standard social events—specifically citing the mini-golf event format (e.g., Puttshack / mini-golf activity) as a superior networking alternative to traditional 18-hole golf tournaments.
- **Maximizing Sponsor-to-Member Interactivity:** Traditional corporate golf outings restrict sales representatives to a single four-person group for four to five hours, limiting overall relationship building. In contrast, casual, flexible event formats allow sponsors to continuously circulate, engage with a wider variety of state GIOs and decision-makers, and gain significantly higher networking ROI.

Appendices

Survey Columns Referenced

Extracted directly from the dataset:

- Member Type
- Job Position/Title
- Length of Involvement
- Event Attendance
- Barriers to Attending Meetings
- Interest in Leadership Role
- Advocacy Priorities
- GMA Agreement Statements
- NGC Communication Effectiveness

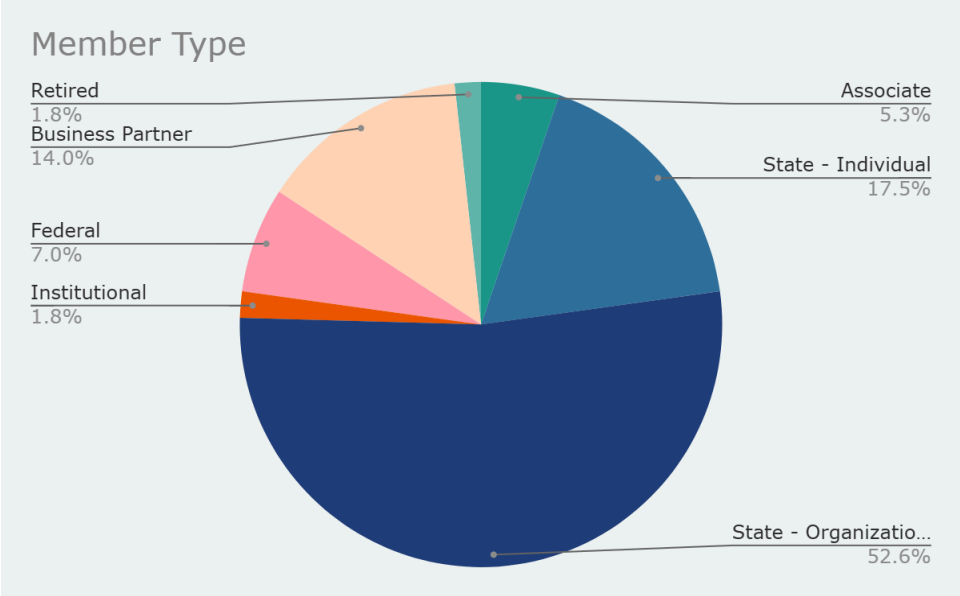
Summary of Narrative Responses

Open-ended feedback addressed:

- Funding instability
- Staffing limitations
- Imagery program needs
- NG911 rollout challenges
- Training opportunities
- Parcel standardization interest
- Desire for national parcel database
- Requests for simplified communications
- Concerns regarding leaf-on grading
- Advocacy for broader state-federal coordination

Tables, Charts and Expanded Information

Member Type Distribution



Job Position / Title Distribution

This chart displays the variety of professional roles represented in the survey. Common titles include GIO (3), GIS Manager (2), and Deputy Director (2). The diversity of positions shows that NSGIC membership spans technical leads, executive decision-makers, mid-level managers, subject-matter specialists, and private-sector representatives, reflecting a richly multidisciplinary geospatial ecosystem.

This table illustrates the wide range of titles represented in the survey.

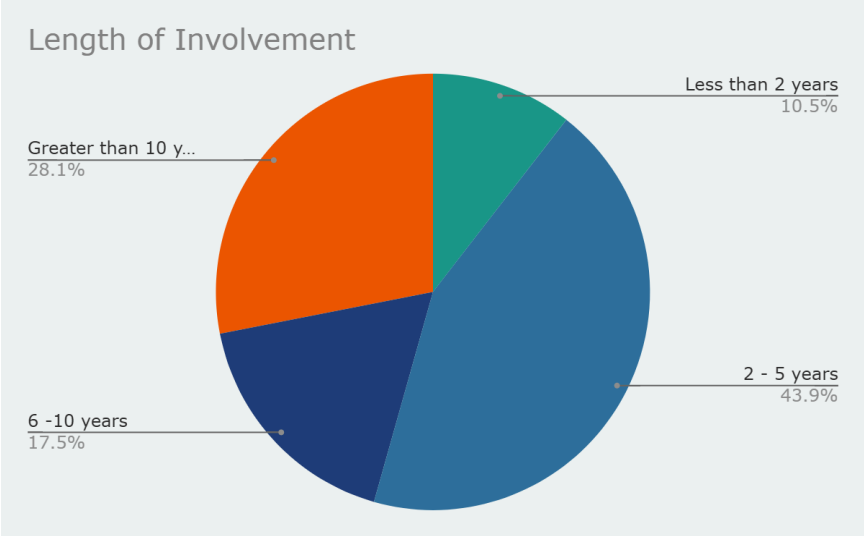
Job Position/Title	Count of Job Position/Title
Assistant Research Scientist	1
Associate Research Scientist	1
Asst Division Chief	1
Biologist	1
Data Analytics Manager	1
Deputy Chief Geographic Information Officer	1
Deputy CIO/GIO	1
Deputy Director	2
Deputy State Cartographer	1
Director	1
Director - Geospatial Information Officer	1
Director of Production	1

Director, Partner Strategies	1
Director, Texas Spatial Reference Center	1
Executive Director	1
Extension Educator	1
FGDC Deputy Executive Director	1
Fisheries GIS Coordinator/Hydrography Data Steward	1
Geographic Data Specialist, Technical Lead for CA Hydrography Stewardship	1
GIO	3
GIS Architect	1
GIS Data Coordinator	1
GIS Director	1
GIS Group Manager	1
GIS Manager	2
GIS Outreach Coordinator	1
GIS Program Coordinator	1
GIS Program Manager	1
GIS Project Manager	1
Hydrography Steward	1
Location Intelligence Analyst	1
Manager	1
Managing Director	1
MN GIO	1
National Data Standard Lead (acting)	1
NYS GIO / Director of Geospatial Services	1
Outreach and Education Coordinator	1
Partner Manager	1
Retired	1
Senior research scientist	1
Senior Scientist	1
Solutions Manager	1
Sr. Revenue Operations Manager	1
Sr. Vice President	1
State Geographic Information Officer	1
State GIO	1
State GIS Coordinator	1
State of NC GIO	1
Supervising GIS Specialist/RIGIS Coordinator	1
Supervisory Geographer	1
TDEC GIS Program Manager	1
VP State and Local Government | BD & Strategy	1
Wyoming State GIS Coordinator	1
(blank)	

Grand Total	57

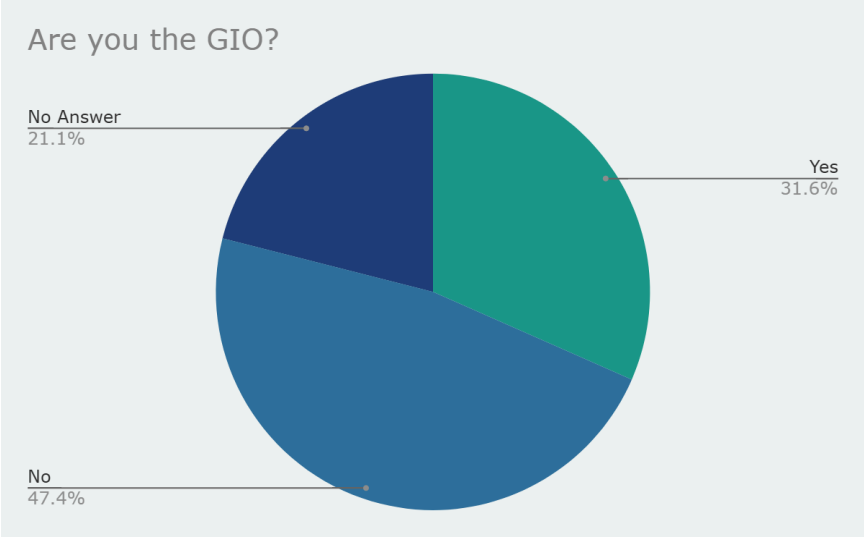
Length of Involvement in NSGIC

This figure summarizes how long respondents have been involved with NSGIC. The largest group reports greater than 10 years, demonstrating strong long-term membership retention. Mid-level experience ranges from 2–5 years to 6–10 years, with newer members (<2 years) also present, representing NSGIC's continual ability to attract new talent. Overall, the data underscores NSGIC's value as a long-standing professional community.



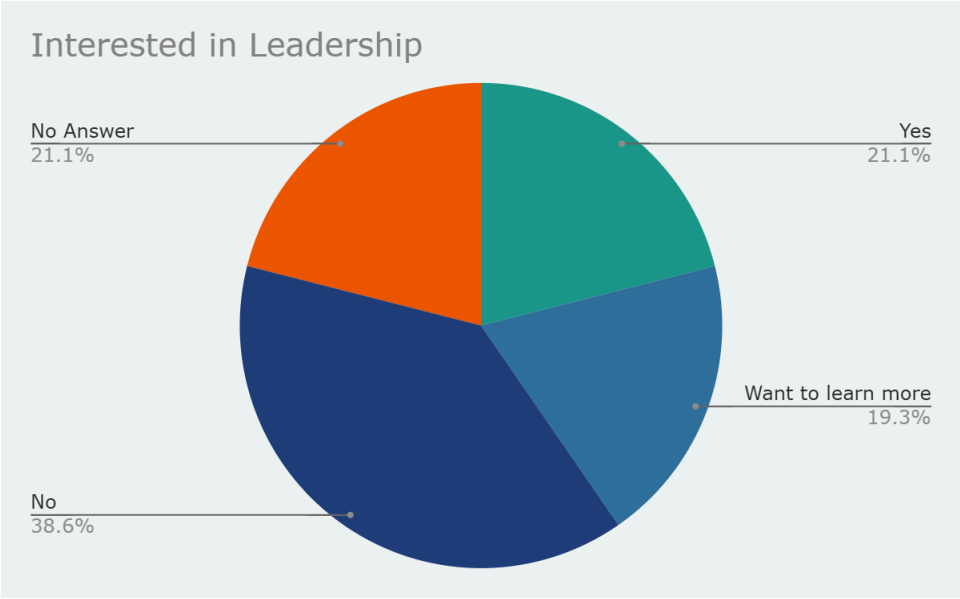
GIO Representation (Yes/No)

A substantial number of respondents do not hold GIO titles but work in state-level GIS programs, reflecting NSGIC's broader statewide engagement beyond official GIO positions. **Those who do hold GIO roles represent a critical leadership segment guiding statewide policy, governance, and data initiatives.**



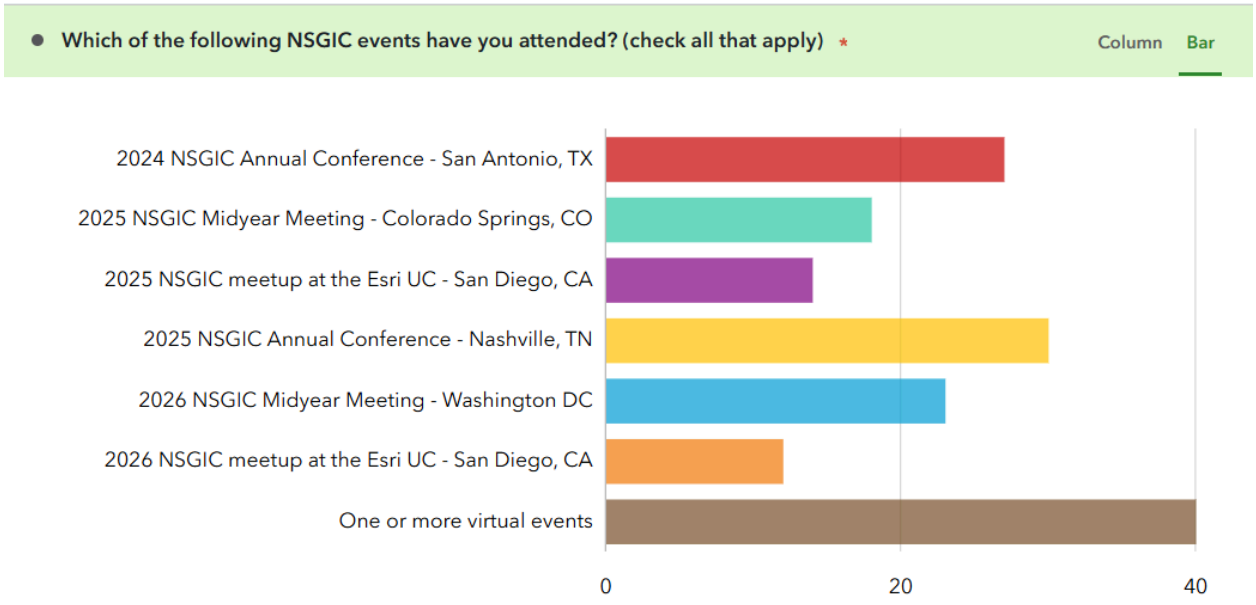
Interest in Leadership Roles

This chart depicts respondent interest in serving in NSGIC leadership roles. A sizeable group expresses interest — often conditional on time availability or approval — while others note constraints such as workload, unfamiliarity with expectations, or agency limitations. The trend indicates an ongoing pipeline of potential leaders who may step into future governance positions as capacity allows.



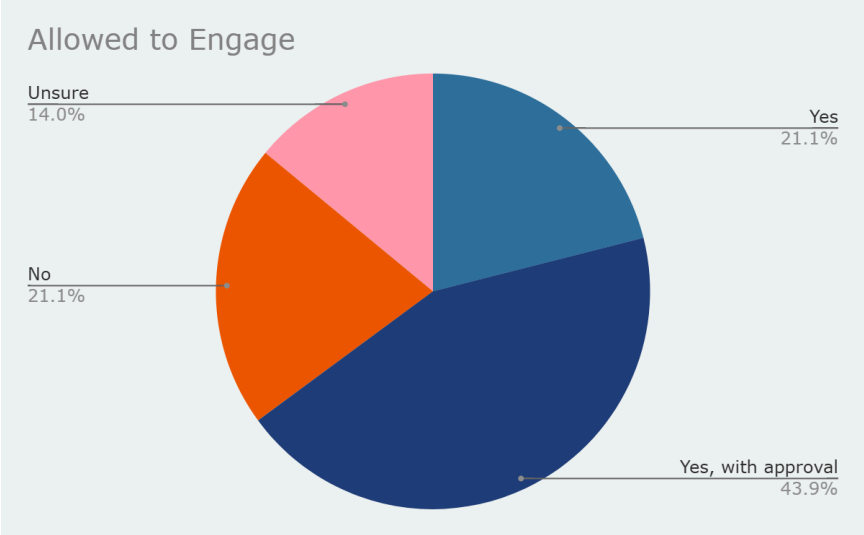
Event Attendance Breakdown

This chart displays the frequency and type of NSGIC events attended by respondents. Common selections include: Annual conferences (2024, 2025, 2026), Midyear meetings, NSGIC meetups (Esri UC), Virtual events. This pattern demonstrates strong interest in national-level engagement, but reveals that virtual options significantly expand participation opportunities.



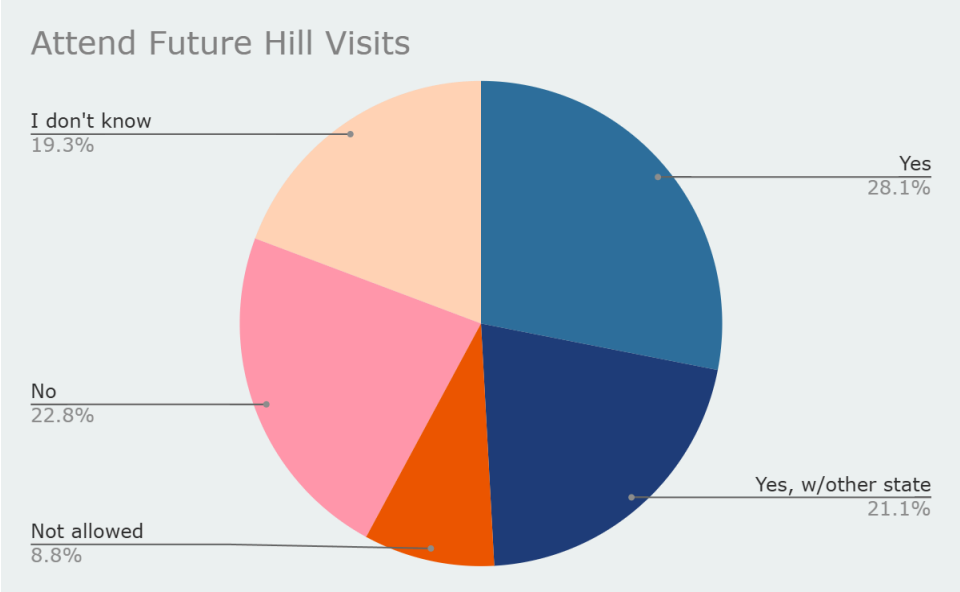
Legislative Engagement Permissions

This figure shows which respondents are allowed to engage their legislature. Many respondents report they are not permitted to do so by agency policy, while others require explicit approval. A smaller group is fully allowed. This suggests NSGIC should continue developing advocacy materials that help members work within varying administrative constraints.



Interest in Attending Capitol Hill Visits

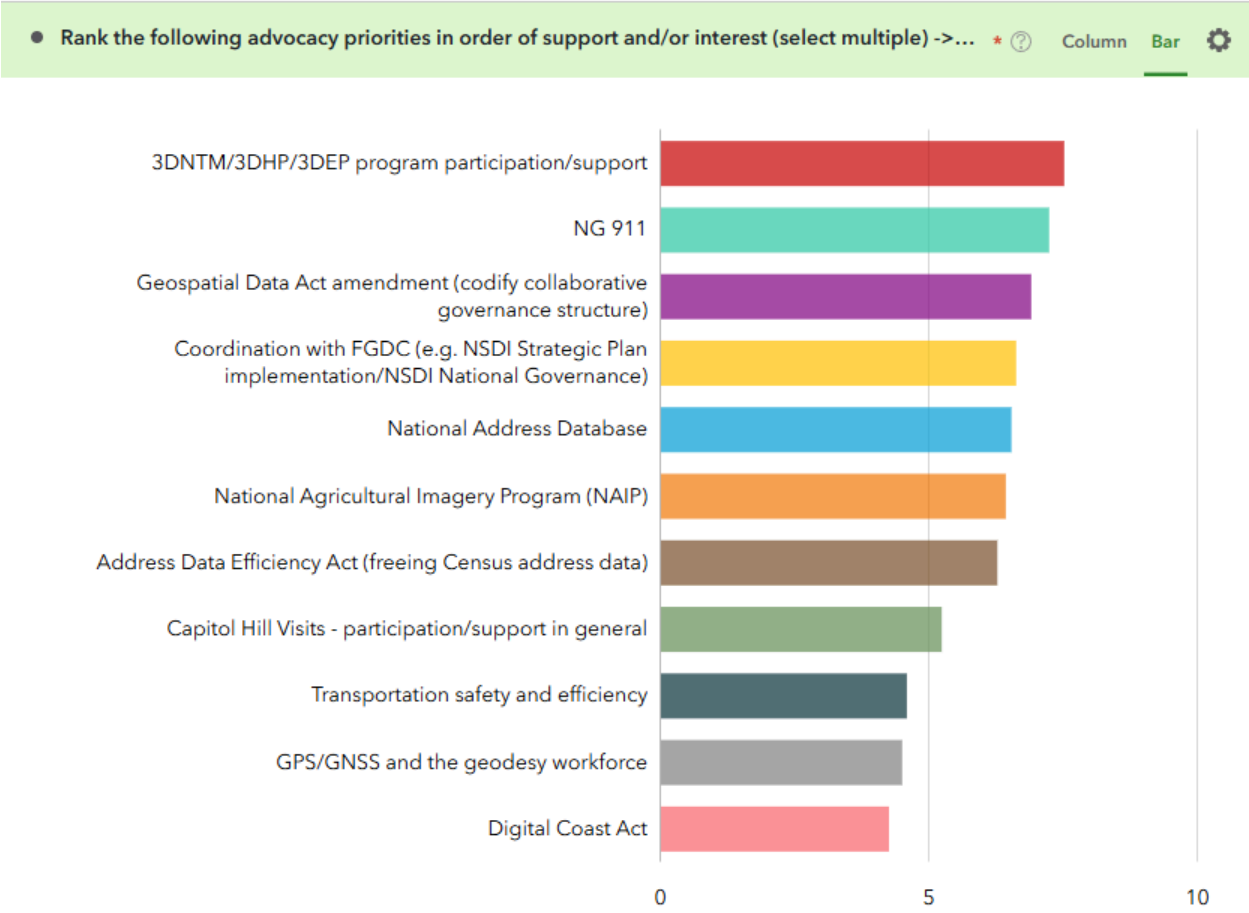
This chart reveals considerable interest in participating in Capitol Hill advocacy — even among respondents who are not currently allowed to engage. The chart demonstrates support for NSGIC's national advocacy program and willingness to contribute when permitted.



National Advocacy Priorities by Category

This data shows counts for **seven advocacy priority groups derived from the Advocacy Priorities field**:

- Addressing/NG911 (68)
- 3D Programs (61)
- Imagery (57)
- Geodesy (54)
- Legislative Advocacy (49)
- Transportation (46)
- FGDC/NSDI (43)



Interpretation:

- **Addressing/NG911** has the highest demand, confirming national alignment on emergency response modernization.
- **3D Programs** (3DEP/3DHP/3DNTM) remain a significant priority, reflecting national needs in elevation and hydrography.

- Imagery and geodesy follow closely, underscoring ongoing nationwide dependency on foundational geospatial datasets.
- Legislative engagement and FGDC coordination also represent meaningful national priorities.

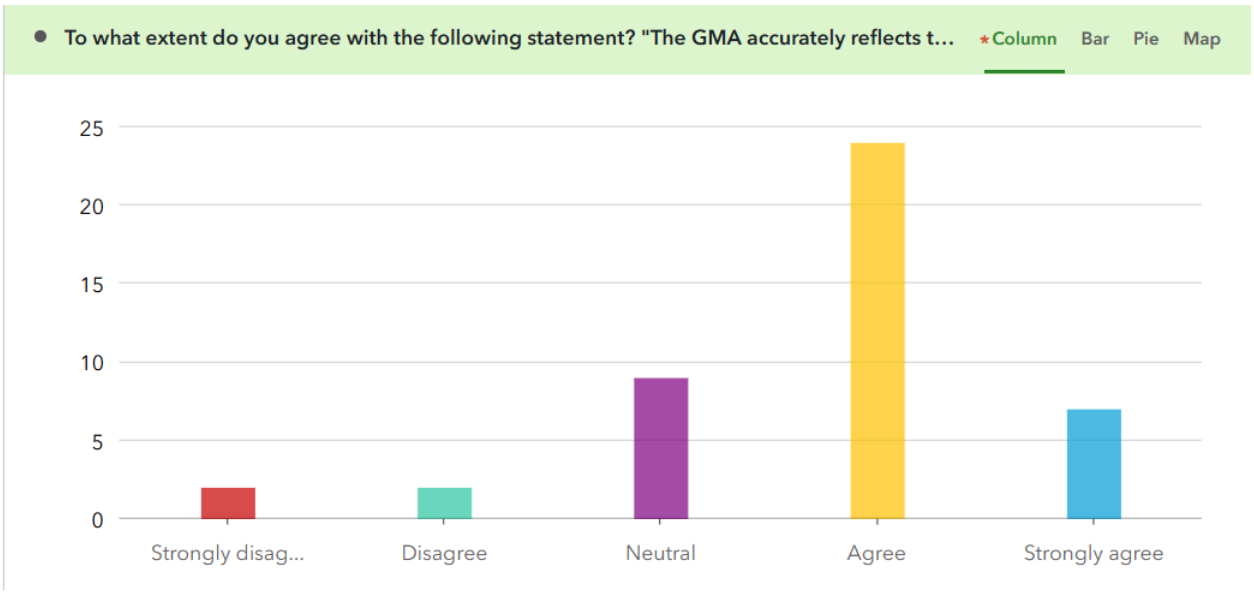
This chart reflects consistent, multi-state alignment with NSDI-related initiatives.

GMA Agreement Responses

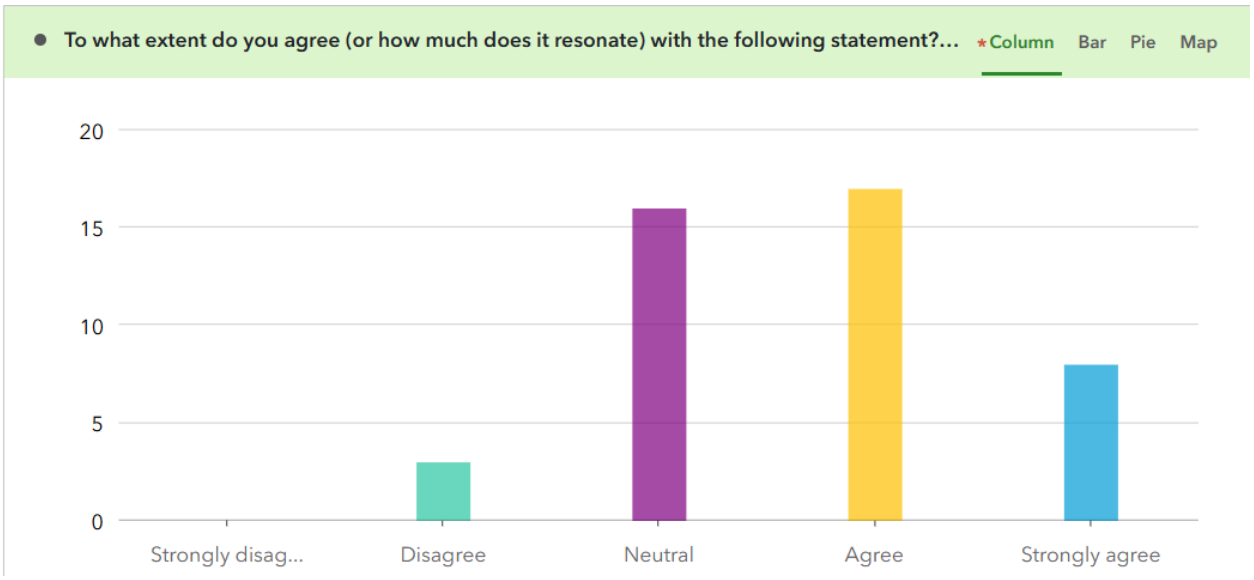
This figure shows member agreement levels regarding the accuracy and usefulness of GMA grading. Results reflect general agreement but with notable concerns:

- Confusion over revised rubric scoring
- Lack of clarity between addressing, transportation, and NG911 grading
- Requests for external validation
- Desire for streamlined assessment processes

The chart displays that while the GMA is widely valued, respondents seek improvements in consistency and clarity.



To what extent do you agree (or how much does it resonate) with the following statement? "My State Spatial Data Infrastructure (SSDI) contributes to and is an integral part of the NSDI."



NGC Communication Effectiveness Rating

This chart demonstrates respondent perceptions of NGC's communications:

- Many respondents marked **neutral**, indicating lack of familiarity
- Others marked **somewhat effective**
- A smaller portion marked **not effective** due to limited visibility

The chart reinforces the need for more frequent updates, simpler messaging about NGC's role, and improved dissemination channels outside NSGIC conferences.

